

The Sports Beat



Sawyer's Resignation May Have Been No Great Surprise To Phillies' Bob Carpenter

By BOB McCURLEY
(Intelligencer Sports Editor)

It seems hard to believe that the resignation of Eddie Sawyer as manager of the Phillies came as much of a surprise to club President Bob Carpenter or General Manager John Quinn. How could they have replaced him so quickly if they had no idea, as they profess, that it was going to happen?

According to the stories dealing with the subject, Carpenter and Sawyer spoke to each other on the phone several times Wednesday night, Sawyer wanting to quit and Carpenter reluctant to accept his resignation. Finally about three o'clock in the morning, Carpenter relented. Then at 10:30 in the morning Carpenter called a press conference at which he announced Sawyer's resignation and the hiring of Gene Mauch, manager of the Minneapolis minor league club. That's getting a new man, and reportedly a good one, on awfully short notice.

Quinn said he recommended Mauch because he (Mauch) had worked for him before and impressed him quite a bit. "Mauch was not a great ball player, but he gave 100 percent of what he had and he was always trying to improve himself. He paid attention to whomever he played for," Quinn said.

Mauch's record as a minor league manager include a third place finish with Atlanta and a second and third place with Minneapolis in the last two years. Mauch is rated by many as one of the best major league managerial prospects in the minors and it is quite surprising that the Phils were able to get him away from the Boston Red Sox, parent club of the Millers.

It is this fact, and that they could get him so fast, which makes one wonder that there wasn't something in the wind before this. It hardly seems possible you can reach into a minor league club, which is the top property of another major league team and pull out one of the best prospects around. It is almost certain there had to be some deals and arrangements made in advance.

Actually, Sawyer's resignation came as no great surprise in this corner. It came sooner than expected, but he hardly figured to finish out the season. The only reason he came back this second time and lasted as long as he did was the fact that he has always been a pet of Carpenters. Granted he piloted the Phillies pennant winning 1950 club, but that took no great amount of managerial skill. The Whiz Kids were a team of desire and probably could have won it by themselves.

Once they had won it, and satisfied this desire, they sank to fifth place the next year with the same club and under the same manager. There are many old time baseball observers who say the late Herb Pennock was head of the Phillies farm system and the man who developed most of the youngsters who made up that team. Herb died in the spring of 1950 and was not around to see his labor bear fruit.

Personally this corner doesn't think Sawyer's heart was in it when he came back to relieve Mayo Smith. He was vice-president of a successful golf ball manufacturing company in Plymouth, Pa., had plenty of time to relax and enjoy life with his wife, children and friends and needed the hectic life of a baseball manager like he needed a nervous breakdown. Then, and now, it seems he did it as a personal favor to Carpenter.

Before leaving the subject, a word of praise should be said about Andy Cohen. The former second baseman of John McGraw's 1924 New York Giants took over the club for Thursday night's home opener with the Milwaukee Braves and out-dresseded Charlie Dressen in the crucial 10th inning when the Phils pushed over the winning run.

Cohen, the regular first base coach with the Phillies, did a magnificent job of bringing his team from behind, shuffling his players, and pulling a big victory out of the hat.

Many thought when he joined the club he might be in line for the manager's job. The same goes for Dick Carter, who coaches at third. Carter was one of the fine young managers in the Phillies farm system who won several pennants for them with their representative in the Eastern League. He is another they brought out of retirement to join the parent club.

However, whether these two will be around with the Phils much longer is doubtful. Generally when a new manager joins a club he brings his own coaches with him. It would be a loss for the Phillies though if Mauch were to dismiss them.

Incidentally, the Pittsburgh Pirates hit the 13 run pool Thursday. Hardly worthwhile.